Chinese political thought and statecraft, which took shape during the formative Qin (221–c. 207 BCE) and Han (206 BCE –220 CE) dynasties, drew inspiration both from the sixth-century-BCE sage Confucius as well as the from the Legalist tradition associated with the Qin dynasty official Han Feizi (who died in 233 BCE). As mentioned earlier, Confucianism set forth a set of political and social norms which would enable a stable, peaceful and harmonious society under an enlightened ruler. Intrinsic to Confucianism is the notion of hierarchy, with each member in society knowing his place and acting according to norms appropriate to his place. This enables order to be maintained and for the state to remain united. The Legalists stressed the absolute authority of the ruler and the use of severe penalties and violent measures to ensure peace and order in a highly centralized and tightly controlled state. Legalists placed less reliance on norms and codes of conduct. Both these strains may be found in the evolution of Chinese political thinking and applied to China's management of relations with the outside world as well.

Confucianism and Legalism also laid great stress on the need for a strong central authority to ensure the peace and prosperity of the state. The weakening of central authority and loss of unity, whatever be the cause, is associated in the Chinese view of its history as exposing the Middle Kingdom to aggression and even occupation by the hostile and less civilized forces ranged along its periphery. There is an innate acceptance, even preference, for strong state authority and authoritarian leadership as assurance of domestic peace and prosperity, to an extent that is more pronounced than in other countries.

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While Chinese attitudes towards the outside world have been shaped by this long history of confronting a hostile and inhospitable periphery, it would be wrong to think of Chinese culture as being wholly insular in character. There was a constant intermingling with different ethnic groups as the Han migrated to regions south of the Yangzi river and absorbed the various tribal communities into the heartland. The opening of the trade routes across